It was Captain Groslow, the reader will remember, who had broken Parry's head.

D'Artagnan resumed immediately the attitude of distrust that was habitual with him. He found the wharf too completely deserted, the night too dark, the captain too accommodating. He had reported to Aramis what had taken place, and Aramis, not less distrustful than he, had increased his suspicions. A slight click of the tongue against his teeth informed Athos of the Gascon's uneasiness.

'We have no time now for suspicions,' said Athos. 'The boat is waiting for us; come.'

'Besides,' said Aramis, 'what prevents our being distrustful and going aboard at the same time? We can watch the skipper.'

'And if he doesn't go straight I will crush him, that's all.'

'Well said, Porthos,' replied D'Artagnan. 'Let us go, then. You first, Mousqueton,' and he stopped his friends, directing the valets to go first, in order to test the plank leading from the pier to the boat.

The three valets passed without accident. Athos followed them, then Porthos, then Aramis. D'Artagnan went last, still shaking his head.

'What in the devil is the matter with you, my friend?' said Porthos. 'Upon my word you would make Cæsar afraid.'

'The matter is,' replied D'Artagnan, 'that I can see upon this pier neither inspector nor sentinel nor exciseman.'

'And you complain of that!' said Porthos. 'Everything goes as if in flowery paths.'

'Everything goes too well, Porthos. But no matter; we must trust in God.'

As soon as the plank was withdrawn the captain took his place at the tiller and made a sign to one of the sailors, who, boat-hook in hand, began to push out from the labyrinth of boats in which they were involved. The other sailor had already seated himself on the port side and was ready to row. As soon as there was room for rowing, his companion rejoined him and the boat began to move more rapidly.

'At last we are off!' exclaimed Porthos.

'Alas,' said Athos, 'we depart alone.'

'Yes; but all four together and without a scratch; which is a consolation.'

'We are not yet at our destination,' observed the prudent D'Artagnan; 'beware of misadventure.'

'Ah, my friend!' cried Porthos, 'like the crows, you always bring bad omens. Who could intercept us on such a night as this, pitch dark, when one does not see more than twenty yards before one?'

'Yes, but to-morrow morning— '

'To-morrow we shall be at Boulogne.'

'I hope so, with all my heart,' said the Gascon, 'and I confess my weakness. Yes, Athos, you may laugh, but as long as we were within gunshot of the pier or of the vessels lying by it I was looking for a frightful discharge of musketry which would crush us.'

'But,' said Porthos, with great wisdom, 'that was impossible, for they would have killed the captain and the sailors.'

'Bah! much Monsieur Mordaunt would care. You don't imagine he would consider a little thing like that?'

'At any rate,' said Porthos, 'I am glad to hear D'Artagnan admit that he is afraid.'

'I not only confess it, but am proud of it,' returned the Gascon; 'I'm not such a rhinoceros as you are. Oho! what's that?'

'The *Lightning*,' answered the captain, 'our felucca.'

'So far, so good,' laughed Athos.

They went on board and the captain instantly conducted them to the berth prepared for them—a cabin which was to serve for all purposes and for the whole party; he then tried to slip away under pretext of giving orders to some one.

'Stop a moment,' cried D'Artagnan; 'pray how many men have you on board, captain?'

'I don't understand,' was the reply.

'Explain it, Athos.'

Groslow, on the question being interpreted, answered, 'Three, without counting myself.'

D'Artagnan understood, for while replying the captain had raised three fingers. 'Oh!' he exclaimed, 'I begin to be more at my ease, however, whilst you settle yourselves, I shall make the round of the boat.'

'As for me,' said Porthos, 'I will see to the supper.'

'A very good idea, Porthos,' said the Gascon. 'Athos lend me Grimaud, who in the society of his friend Parry has perhaps picked up a little English, and can act as my interpreter.'

'Go, Grimaud,' said Athos.

D'Artagnan, finding a lantern on the deck, took it up and with a pistol in his hand he said to the captain, in English, 'Come,' (being, with the classic English oath, the only English words he knew), and so saying he descended to the lower deck.

This was divided into three compartments—one which was covered by the floor of that room in which Athos, Porthos and Aramis were to pass the night; the second was to serve as the sleeping-room for the servants, the third, under the prow of the ship, was under the temporary cabin in which Mordaunt was concealed.

'Oho!' cried D'Artagnan, as he went down the steps of the hatchway, preceded by the lantern, 'what a number of barrels! one would think one was in the cave of Ali Baba. What is there in them?' he added, putting his lantern on one of the casks.

The captain seemed inclined to go upon deck again, but controlling himself he answered:

'Port wine.'

'Ah! port wine! 'tis a comfort,' said the Gascon, 'since we shall not die of thirst. Are they all full?'

Grimaud translated the question, and Groslow, who was wiping the perspiration from off his forehead, answered:

'Some full, others empty.'

D'Artagnan struck the barrels with his hand, and having ascertained that he spoke the truth, pushed his lantern, greatly to the captain's alarm, into the interstices between the barrels, and finding that there was nothing concealed in them:

'Come along,' he said; and he went toward the door of the second compartment.

'Stop!' said the Englishman, 'I have the key of that door;' and he opened the door, with a trembling hand, into the second compartment, where Mousqueton and Blaisois were preparing supper.

superfluous; nevertheless, the keen glance of Athos perceived at once it was not Rogers who stood before them.

'What do you want with us?' he asked of Groslow.

'I wish to inform you, my lord,' replied Groslow, with an Irish accent, feigned of course, 'that if you are looking for Captain Rogers you will not find him. He fell down this morning and broke his leg. But I'm his cousin; he told me everything and desired me to watch instead of him, and in his place to conduct, wherever they wished to go, the gentlemen who should bring me a handkerchief tied at each corner, like that one which you hold and one which I have in my pocket.'

And he drew out the handkerchief.

'Was that all he said?' inquired Athos.

'No, my lord; he said you had engaged to pay seventy pounds if I landed you safe and sound at Boulogne or any other port you choose in France.'

'What do you think of all this?' said Athos, in a low tone to D'Artagnan, after explaining to him in French what the sailor had said in English.

'It seems a likely story to *me*.'

'And to me, too.'

'Besides, we can but blow out his brains if he proves false,' said the Gascon; 'and you, Athos, you know something of everything and can be our captain. I dare say you know how to navigate, should he fail us.'

'My dear friend, you guess well. My father meant me for the navy and I have some vague notions about navigation.'

'You see!' cried D'Artagnan.

They then summoned their friends, who, with Blaisois, Mousqueton and Grimaud, promptly joined them, leaving Parry behind them, who was to take back to London the horses of the gentlemen and of their lackeys, which had been sold to the host in settlement of their account with him. Thanks to this stroke of business the four friends were able to take away with them a sum of money which, if not large, was sufficient as a provision against delays and accidents.

Parry parted from his friends regretfully; they had proposed his going with them to France, but he had straightway declined.

'It is very simple,' Mousqueton had said; 'he is thinking of Groslow.'

He went with Groslow to the captain's berth, a sort of temporary cabin of planks, for the chief apartment had been given up by Captain Rogers to the passengers, who were to be accommodated at the other end of the boat.

'They will have nothing to do, then at this end?' said Mordaunt.

'Nothing at all.'

'That's a capital arrangement. Return to Greenwich and bring them here. I shall hide myself in your cabin. You have a longboat?'

'That in which we came.'

'It appeared light and well constructed.'

'Quite a canoe.'

'Fasten it to the poop with a rope; put the oars into it, so that it may follow in the track and there will be nothing to do except to cut the cord. Put a good supply of rum and biscuit in it for the seamen; should the night happen to be stormy they will not be sorry to find something to console themselves with.'

'Consider all this done. Do you wish to see the powder-room?'

'No. When you return I will set the fuse myself, but be careful to conceal your face, so that you cannot be recognised by them.'

'Never fear.'

'There's ten o'clock striking at Greenwich.'

Groslow, then, having given the sailor on duty an order to be on the watch with more than usual vigilance, went down into the longboat and soon reached Greenwich. The wind was chilly and the jetty was deserted, as he approached it; but he had no sooner landed than he heard a noise of horses galloping upon the paved road.

These horsemen were our friends, or rather, an avant garde, composed of D'Artagnan and Athos. As soon as they arrived at the spot where Groslow stood they stopped, as if guessing that he was the man they wanted. Athos alighted and calmly opened the handkerchief tied at each corner, whilst D'Artagnan, ever cautious, remained on horseback, one hand upon his pistol, leaning forward watchfully.

On seeing the appointed signal, Groslow, who had at first crept behind one of the cannons planted on that spot, walked straight up to the gentlemen. He was so well wrapped up in his cloak that it would have been impossible to see his face even if the night had not been so dark as to render precaution

Here there was evidently nothing to seek or to apprehend and they passed rapidly to examine the third compartment.

This was the room appropriated to the sailors. Two or three hammocks hung upon the ceiling, a table and two benches composed the entire furniture. D'Artagnan picked up two or three old sails hung on the walls, and meeting nothing to suspect, regained by the hatchway the deck of the vessel.

'And this room?' he asked, pointing to the captain's cabin.

'That's my room,' replied Groslow.

'Open the door.'

The captain obeyed. D'Artagnan stretched out his arm in which he held the lantern, put his head in at the half opened door, and seeing that the cabin was nothing better than a shed:

'Good,' he said. 'If there is an army on board it is not here that it is hidden. Let us see what Porthos has found for supper.' And thanking the captain, he regained the state cabin, where his friends were.

Porthos had found nothing, and with him fatigue had prevailed over hunger. He had fallen asleep and was in a profound slumber when D'Artagnan returned. Athos and Aramis were beginning to close their eyes, which they half opened when their companion came in again.

'Well!' said Aramis.

'All is well; we may sleep tranquilly.'

On this assurance the two friends fell asleep; and D'Artagnan, who was very weary, bade good-night to Grimaud and laid himself down in his cloak, with naked sword at his side, in such a manner that his body barricaded the passage, and it should be impossible to enter the room without upsetting him.

'To embark with you.'

'Ah! ah! the general doubted my fidelity?'

'No, but I wish to have a share in my revenge. Haven't you some one who will relieve me of my horse?'

Groslow whistled and a sailor appeared.

'Patrick,' said Groslow, 'take this horse to the stables of the nearest inn. If any one asks you whose it is you can say that it belongs to an Irish gentleman.'

The sailor departed without reply.

'Now,' said Mordaunt, 'are you not afraid that they will recognise you?'

'There is no danger, dressed as I am in this pilot coat, on a night as dark as this. Besides even you didn't recognise me; they will be much less likely to.'

'That is true,' said Mordaunt, 'and they will be far from thinking of you. Everything is ready, is it not?'

'Yes.'

'The cargo on board?'

'Yes.'

'Five full casks?'

'And fifty empty ones.'

'Good.'

'We are carrying port wine to Anvers.'

'Excellent. Now take me aboard and return to your post, for they will soon be here.'

'I am ready.'

'It is important that none of your crew should see me.'

'I have but one man on board, and I am as sure of him as I am of myself. Besides, he doesn't know you; like his mates he is ready to obey our orders knowing nothing of our plan.'

'Very well; let us go.'

They then went down to the Thames. A boat was fastened to the shore by a chain fixed to a stake. Groslow jumped in, followed by Mordaunt, and in five minutes they were quite away from that world of houses which then crowded the outskirts of London; and Mordaunt could discern the little vessel riding at anchor near the Isle of Dogs. When they reached the side of this felucca, Mordaunt, dexterous in his eagerness for vengeance, seized a rope and climbed up the side of the vessel with a coolness and agility very rare among landsmen.

I was! I have almost killed myself by my needless haste. Now,' he added, rising in the stirrups and looking about him, 'which, I wonder, is the *Lightning*?'

At this moment, as if in reply to his words, a man lying on a coil of cables rose and advanced a few steps toward him. Mordaunt drew a handkerchief from his pocket, and tying a knot at each corner—the signal agreed upon—waved it in the air and the man came up to him. He was wrapped in a large rough cape, which concealed his form and partly his face.

'Do you wish to go on the water, sir?' said the sailor.

'Yes, just so. Along the Isle of Dogs.'

'And perhaps you have a preference for one boat more than another. You would like one that sails as rapidly as— '

'Lightning,' interrupted Mordaunt.

'Then mine is the boat you want, sir. I'm your man.'

'I begin to think so, particularly if you have not forgotten a certain signal.'

'Here it is, sir,' and the sailor took from his coat a handkerchief, tied at each corner.

'Good, quite right!' cried Mordaunt, springing off his horse. 'There's not a moment to lose; now take my horse to the nearest inn and conduct me to your vessel.'

'But,' asked the sailor, 'where are your companions? I thought there were four of you.'

'Listen to me, sir. I'm not the man you take me for; you are in Captain Rogers's post, are you not? under orders from General Cromwell. Mine, also, are from him!'

'Indeed, sir, I recognise you; you are Captain Mordaunt.'

Mordaunt was startled.

'Oh, fear nothing,' said the skipper, showing his face. 'I am a friend.'

'Captain Groslow!' cried Mordaunt.

'Himself. The general remembered that I had formerly been a naval officer and he gave me the command of this expedition. Is there anything new in the wind?'

'Nothing.'

'I thought, perhaps, that the king's death— '

'Has only hastened their flight; in ten minutes they will perhaps be here.'

'What have you come for, then?'

Chapter LXXI

Port Wine

In ten minutes the masters slept; not so the servants—-hungry, and more thirsty than hungry.

Blaisois and Mousqueton set themselves to preparing their bed which consisted of a plank and a valise. On a hanging table, which swung to and fro with the rolling of the vessel, were a pot of beer and three glasses.

'This cursed rolling!' said Blaisois. 'I know it will serve me as it did when we came over.'

'And to think,' said Mousqueton, 'that we have nothing to fight seasickness with but barley bread and hop beer. Pah!'

'But where is your wicker flask, Monsieur Mousqueton? Have you lost it?' asked Blaisois.

'No,' replied Mousqueton, 'Parry kept it. Those devilish Scotchmen are always thirsty. And you, Grimaud,' he said to his companion, who had just come in after his round with D'Artagnan, 'are you thirsty?'

'As thirsty as a Scotchman!' was Grimaud's laconic reply.

And he sat down and began to cast up the accounts of his party, whose money he managed.

'Oh, lackadaisy! I'm beginning to feel queer!' cried Blaisois.

'If that's the case,' said Mousqueton, with a learned air, 'take some nourishment.'

'Do you call that nourishment?' said Blaisois, pointing to the barley bread and pot of beer upon the table.

'Blaisois,' replied Mousqueton, 'remember that bread is the true nourishment of a Frenchman, who is not always able to get bread, ask Grimaud.'

'Yes, but beer?' asked Blaisois sharply, 'is that their true drink?'

'As to that,' answered Mousqueton, puzzled how to get out of the difficulty, 'I must confess that to me beer is as disagreeable as wine is to the English.'

'What! Monsieur Mousqueton! The English—do they dislike wine?'

'They hate it.'

'But I have seen them drink it.'

'As a punishment. For example, an English prince died one day because they had put him into a butt of Malmsey. I heard the Chevalier d'Herblay say so.'

'The fool!' cried Blaisois, 'I wish I had been in his place.'

'Thou canst be,' said Grimaud, writing down his figures.

'How?' asked Blaisois, 'I can? Explain yourself.'

Grimaud went on with his sum and cast up the whole.

'Port,' he said, extending his hand in the direction of the first compartment examined by D'Artagnan and himself.

'Eh? eh? ah? Those barrels I saw through the door?'

'Port!' replied Grimaud, beginning a fresh sum.

'I have heard,' said Blaisois, 'that port is a very good wine.'

'Excellent!' exclaimed Mousqueton, smacking his lips. 'Excellent; there is port wine in the cellar of Monsieur le Baron de Bracieux.'

'Suppose we ask these Englishmen to sell us a bottle,' said the honest Blaisois.

'Sell!' cried Mousqueton, about whom there was a remnant of his ancient marauding character left. 'One may well perceive, young man, that you are inexperienced. Why buy what one can take?'

'Take!' said Blaisois; 'covet the goods of your neighbour? That is forbidden, it seems to me.'

'Where forbidden?' asked Mousqueton.

'In the commandments of God, or of the church, I don't know which. I only know it says, "Thou shalt not covet thy neighbour's goods, nor yet his wife."'

'That is a child's reason, Monsieur Blaisois,' said Mousqueton in his most patronizing manner. 'Yes, you talk like a child—I repeat the word. Where have you read in the Scriptures, I ask you, that the English are your neighbours?'

'Where, that is true,' said Blaisois; 'at least, I can't now recall it.'

Chapter LXX

The Skiff *Lightning*

D'Artagnan had judged correctly; Mordaunt felt that he had no time to lose, and he lost none. He knew the rapidity of decision and action that characterised his enemies and resolved to act with reference to that. This time the musketeers had an adversary who was worthy of them.

After closing the door carefully behind him Mordaunt glided into the subterranean passage, sheathing on the way his now useless sword, and thus reached the neighbouring house, where he paused to examine himself and to take breath.

'Good!' he said, 'nothing, almost nothing—scratches, nothing more; two in the arm and one in the breast. The wounds that I make are better than that—witness the executioner of Bethune, my uncle and King Charles. Now, not a second to lose, for a second lost will perhaps save them. They must die—die all together—killed at one stroke by the thunder of men in default of God's. They must disappear, broken, scattered, annihilated. I will run, then, till my legs no longer serve, till my heart bursts in my bosom but I will arrive before they do.'

Mordaunt proceeded at a rapid pace to the nearest cavalry barracks, about a quarter of a league distant. He made that quarter of a league in four or five minutes. Arrived at the barracks he made himself known, took the best horse in the stables, mounted and gained the high road. A quarter of an hour later he was at Greenwich.

'There is the port,' he murmured. 'That dark point yonder is the Isle of Dogs. Good! I am half an hour in advance of them, an hour, perhaps. Fool that

'Really!' said D'Artagnan, abandoning the attempt to burst open the panel after several ineffectual attempts, 'Athos, I cannot imagine how you can talk to us in that way. You cannot understand the position we are in. In this kind of game, not to kill is to let one's self be killed. This fox of a fellow will be sending us a hundred iron-sided beasts who will pick us off like sparrows in this place. Come, come, we must be off. If we stay here five minutes more there's an end of us.'

'Yes, you are right.'

'But where shall we go?' asked Porthos.

'To the hotel, to be sure, to get our baggage and horses; and from there, if it please God, to France, where, at least, I understand the architecture of the houses.'

So, suiting the action to the word, D'Artagnan thrust the remnant of his sword into its scabbard, picked up his hat and ran down the stairs, followed by the others.

'A child's reason—I repeat it,' continued Mousqueton. 'If you had been ten years engaged in war, as Grimaud and I have been, my dear Blaisois, you would know the difference there is between the goods of others and the goods of enemies. Now an Englishman is an enemy; this port wine belongs to the English, therefore it belongs to us.'

'And our masters?' asked Blaisois, stupefied by this harangue, delivered with an air of profound sagacity, 'will they be of your opinion?'

Mousqueton smiled disdainfully.

'I suppose that you think it necessary that I should disturb the repose of these illustrious lords to say, "Gentlemen, your servant, Mousqueton, is thirsty." What does Monsieur Bracieux care, think you, whether I am thirsty or not?'

''Tis a very expensive wine,' said Blaisois, shaking his head.

'Were it liquid gold, Monsieur Blaisois, our masters would not deny themselves this wine. Know that Monsieur de Bracieux is rich enough to drink a tun of port wine, even if obliged to pay a pistole for every drop.' His manner became more and more lofty every instant; then he arose and after finishing off the beer at one draught he advanced majestically to the door of the compartment where the wine was. 'Ah! locked!' he exclaimed; 'these devils of English, how suspicious they are!'

'Locked!' said Blaisois; 'ah! the deuce it is; unlucky, for my stomach is getting more and more upset.'

'Locked!' repeated Mousqueton.

'But,' Blaisois ventured to say, 'I have heard you relate, Monsieur Mousqueton, that once on a time, at Chantilly, you fed your master and yourself by taking partridges in a snare, carp with a line, and bottles with a slipnoose.'

'Perfectly true; but there was an airhole in the cellar and the wine was in bottles. I cannot throw the loop through this partition nor move with a pack-thread a cask of wine which may perhaps weigh two hundred pounds.'

'No, but you can take out two or three boards of the partition,' answered Blaisois, 'and make a hole in the cask with a gimlet.'

Mousqueton opened his great round eyes to the utmost, astonished to find in Blaisois qualities for which he did not give him credit.

''Tis true,' he said; 'but where can I get a chisel to take the planks out, a gimlet to pierce the cask?'

'Trousers,' said Grimaud, still squaring his accounts.

'Ah, yes!' said Mousqueton.

Grimaud, in fact, was not only the accountant, but the armourer of the party; and as he was a man full of forethought, these trousers, carefully rolled up in his valise, contained every sort of tool for immediate use.

Mousqueton, therefore, was soon provided with tools and he began his task. In a few minutes he had extracted three boards. He tried to pass his body through the aperture, but not being like the frog in the fable, who thought he was larger than he really was, he found he must take out three or four more before he could get through.

He sighed and set to work again.

Grimaud had now finished his accounts. He arose and stood near Mousqueton.

'I,' he said.

'What?' said Mousqueton.

'I can pass.'

'That is true,' said Mousqueton, glancing at his friend's long and thin body, 'you will pass easily.'

'And he knows the full casks,' said Blaisois, 'for he has already been in the hold with Monsieur le Chevalier d'Artagnan. Let Monsieur Grimaud go in, Monsieur Mouston.'

'I could go in as well as Grimaud,' said Mousqueton, a little piqued.

'Yes, but that would take too much time and I am thirsty. I am getting more and more seasick.'

'Go in, then, Grimaud,' said Mousqueton, handing him the beer pot and gimlet.

'Rinse the glasses,' said Grimaud. Then with a friendly gesture toward Mousqueton, that he might forgive him for finishing an enterprise so brilliantly begun by another, he glided like a serpent through the opening and disappeared.

Blaisois was in a state of great excitement; he was in ecstasies. Of all the exploits performed since their arrival in England by the extraordinary men with whom he had the honour to be associated, this seemed without question to be the most wonderful.

He smiled more and more sarcastically and his smile began to make the Gascon anxious.

'Come, come,' cried D'Artagnan, 'we must finish with this,' and in his turn he pressed Mordaunt hard, who continued to lose ground, but evidently on purpose and without letting his sword leave the line for a moment. However, as they were fighting in a room and had not space to go on like that forever, Mordaunt's foot at last touched the wall, against which he rested his left hand.

'Ah, this time you cannot lose ground, my fine friend!' exclaimed D'Artagnan. 'Gentlemen, did you ever see a scorpion pinned to a wall? No. Well, then, you shall see it now.'

In a second D'Artagnan had made three terrible thrusts at Mordaunt, all of which touched, but only pricked him. The three friends looked on, panting and astonished. At last D'Artagnan, having got up too close, stepped back to prepare a fourth thrust, but the moment when, after a fine, quick feint, he was attacking as sharply as lightning, the wall seemed to give way, Mordaunt disappeared through the opening, and D'Artagnan's blade, caught between the panels, shivered like a sword of glass. D'Artagnan sprang back; the wall had closed again.

Mordaunt, in fact, while defending himself, had manœuvred so as to reach the secret door by which Cromwell had left, had felt for the knob with his left hand, pressed it and disappeared.

The Gascon uttered a furious imprecation, which was answered by a wild laugh on the other side of the iron panel.

'Help me, gentlemen,' cried D'Artagnan, 'we must break in this door.'

'It is the devil in person!' said Aramis, hastening forward.

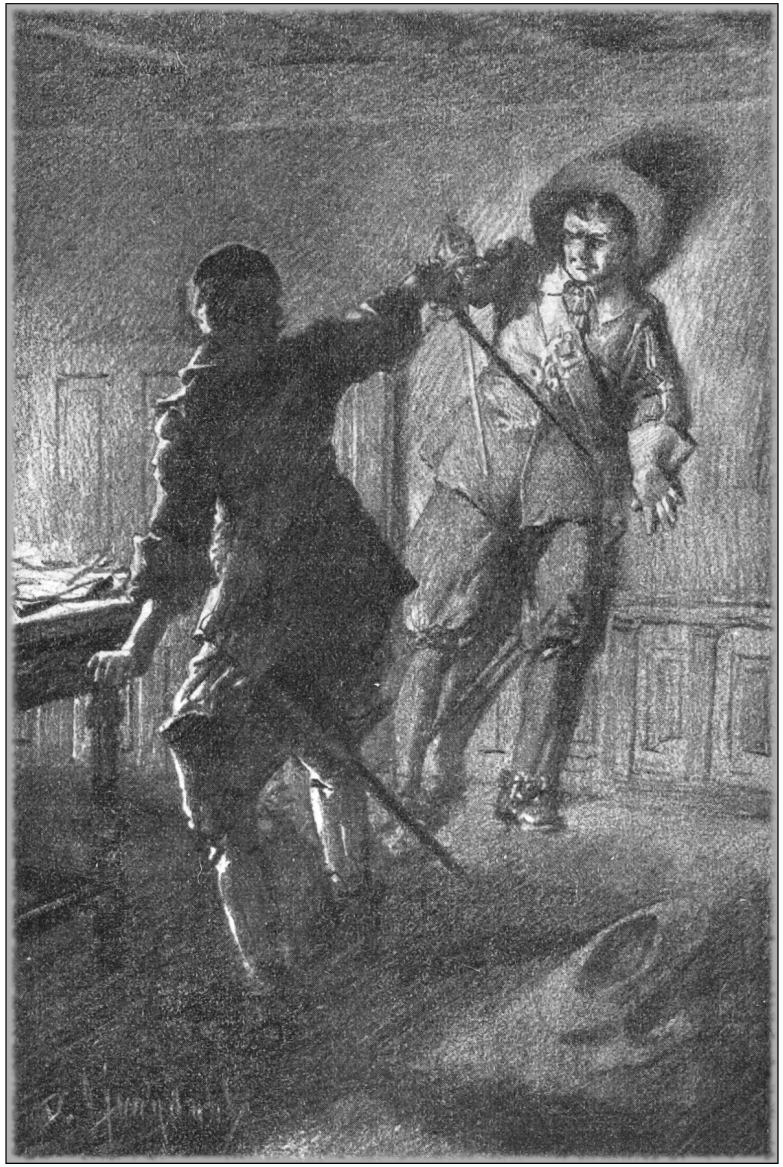
'He escapes us,' growled Porthos, pushing his huge shoulder against the hinges, but in vain. ''Sblood! he escapes us.'

'So much the better,' muttered Athos.

'I thought as much,' said D'Artagnan, wasting his strength in useless efforts. 'Zounds, I thought as much when the wretch kept moving around the room. I thought he was up to something.'

'It's a misfortune, to which his friend, the devil, treats us,' said Aramis.

'It's a piece of good fortune sent from Heaven,' said Athos, evidently much relieved.



Mordaunt rapidly sprang back a step

'You are about to see,' said Mousqueton, looking at Blaisois with an expression of superiority which the latter did not even think of questioning, 'you are about to see, Blaisois, how we old soldiers drink when we are thirsty.'

'My cloak,' said Grimaud, from the bottom of the hold.

'What do you want?' asked Blaisois.

'My cloak—stop up the aperture with it.'

'Why?' asked Blaisois.

'Simpleton!' exclaimed Mousqueton; 'suppose any one came into the room.'

'Ah, true,' cried Blaisois, with evident admiration; 'but it will be dark in the cellar.'

'Grimaud always sees, dark or light, night as well as day,' answered Mousqueton.

'That is lucky,' said Blaisois. 'As for me, when I have no candle I can't take two steps without knocking against something.'

'That's because you haven't served,' said Mousqueton. 'Had you been in the army you would have been able to pick up a needle on the floor of a closed oven. But hark! I think some one is coming.'

Mousqueton made, with a low whistling sound, the sign of alarm well known to the lackeys in the days of their youth, resumed his place at the table and made a sign to Blaisois to follow his example.

Blaisois obeyed.

The door of their cabin was opened. Two men, wrapped in their cloaks, appeared.

'Oho!' said they, 'not in bed at a quarter past eleven. That's against all rules. In a quarter of an hour let every one be in bed and snoring.'

These two men then went toward the compartment in which Grimaud was secreted; opened the door, entered and shut it after them.

'Ah!' cried Blaisois, 'he is lost!'

'Grimaud's a cunning fellow,' murmured Mousqueton.

They waited for ten minutes, during which time no noise was heard that might indicate that Grimaud was discovered, and at the expiration of that anxious interval the two men returned, closed the door after them, and repeating their orders that the servants should go to bed and extinguish their lights, disappeared.

'Shall we obey?' asked Blaisois. 'All this looks suspicious.'

'They said a quarter of an hour. We still have five minutes,' replied Mousqueton.

'Suppose we warn the masters.'

'Let's wait for Grimaud.'

'But perhaps they have killed him.'

'Grimaud would have cried out.'

'You know he is almost dumb.'

'We should have heard the blow, then.'

'But if he doesn't return?'

'Here he is.'

At that very moment Grimaud drew back the cloak which hid the aperture and came in with his face livid, his eyes staring wide open with terror, so that the pupils were contracted almost to nothing, with a large circle of white around them. He held in his hand a tankard full of a dark substance, and approaching the gleam of light shed by the lamp he uttered this single monosyllable: 'Oh!' with such an expression of extreme terror that Mousqueton started, alarmed, and Blaisois was near fainting from fright.

Both, however, cast an inquisitive glance into the tankard—it was full of gunpowder.

Convinced that the ship was full of powder instead of having a cargo of wine, Grimaud hastened to awake D'Artagnan, who had no sooner beheld him than he perceived that something extraordinary had taken place. Imposing silence, Grimaud put out the little night lamp, then knelt down and poured into the lieutenant's ear a recital melodramatic enough not to require play of feature to give it pith.

This was the gist of his strange story:

The first barrel that Grimaud had found on passing into the compartment he struck—it was empty. He passed on to another—it, also, was empty, but the third which he tried was, from the dull sound it gave out, evidently full. At this point Grimaud stopped and was preparing to make a hole with his gimlet, when he found a spigot; he therefore placed his tankard under it and turned the spout; something, whatever it was the cask contained, fell silently into the tankard.

'It is for something else than that, I imagine,' muttered D'Artagnan, shaking his head doubtfully.

'On the honour of gentlemen,' said Aramis and Porthos.

'In that case, gentlemen, have the kindness to retire into the corners, so as to give us ample room. We shall require it.'

'Yes, gentlemen,' said D'Artagnan, 'we must not leave this person the slightest pretext for behaving badly, which, with all due respect, I fancy he is anxious still to do.'

This new attack made no impression on Mordaunt. The space was cleared, the two lamps placed on Cromwell's desk, in order that the combatants might have as much light as possible; and the swords crossed.

D'Artagnan was too good a swordsman to trifle with his opponent. He made a rapid and brilliant feint which Mordaunt parried.

'Aha!' he cried with a smile of satisfaction.

And without losing a minute, thinking he saw an opening, he thrust his right in and forced Mordaunt to parry a counter *en quarte* so fine that the point of the weapon might have turned within a wedding ring.

This time it was Mordaunt who smiled.

'Ah, sir,' said D'Artagnan, 'you have a wicked smile. It must have been the devil who taught it you, was it not?'

Mordaunt replied by trying his opponent's weapon with an amount of strength which the Gascon was astonished to find in a form apparently so feeble; but thanks to a parry no less clever than that which Mordaunt had just achieved, he succeeded in meeting his sword, which slid along his own without touching his chest.

Mordaunt rapidly sprang back a step.

'Ah! you lose ground, you are turning? Well, as you please, I even gain something by it, for I no longer see that wicked smile of yours. You have no idea what a false look you have, particularly when you are afraid. Look at my eyes and you will see what no looking-glass has ever shown you—a frank and honourable countenance.'

To this flow of words, not perhaps in the best taste, but characteristic of D'Artagnan, whose principal object was to divert his opponent's attention, Mordaunt did not reply, but continuing to turn around he succeeded in changing places with D'Artagnan.